MealMap — Team Setup Guide

Getting Your Mac Ready to Build

April 2026 | For all team members | No prior experience assumed

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> **How to read this guide** Every step starts with a **check first** box. If the check passes (you already have it), skip to the next step. If it fails, follow the install instructions below it. Think of this like a pre-flight checklist — a pilot doesn't re-install the engines every flight, they just verify they're there.

⚠️ Important: API Keys Are Not Your Claude Pro Account

Your Claude Pro subscription (claude.ai) and the Anthropic API are **two separate things** — like how a Spotify subscription doesn't let you embed Spotify music in your own app. MealMap makes direct API calls, which requires a separate API key from **console.anthropic.com**. Deb will coordinate one shared API key for the team during build week — **do not each create separate accounts and start billing individually.**

PART 1 — Pre-Flight Checks (Do These First)

Open **Terminal** on your Mac:

- Press `Command (⌘) + Space` → type `Terminal` → press Enter
- A black or white window with a blinking cursor will appear. This is normal.

Run each check below by **copying the command exactly, pasting it in Terminal, and pressing Enter**.

Check 1 — Node.js

Node.js is the engine that runs the MealMap app on your computer. Think of it like the Java runtime for a Java app — without it, nothing runs.

Check:

```
node --version
```

✅ **Pass:** You see something like `v20.x.x` or higher → skip to Check 2. ❌ **Fail:** You see `command not found` → follow **Install A** below.

Install A — Node.js

1. Go to **https://nodejs.org**
2. Click the big green button labelled **"LTS"** (Long Term Support) — not the "Current" one
3. The `.pkg` file will download to your Downloads folder
4. Double-click it → click through the installer prompts → click Install
5. When it finishes, close and reopen Terminal, then run `node --version` again to confirm

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Check 2 — npm (comes with Node.js)

npm is the package manager — it downloads the code libraries that MealMap depends on. It installs automatically with Node.js.

Check:

```
npm --version
```

✅ **Pass:** You see a version number like `10.x.x` → skip to Check 3. ❌ **Fail:** Re-run Install A above (npm comes bundled with Node.js).

Check 3 — Git

Git is version control — it's what lets the whole team work on the same codebase without overwriting each other's work. Think of it like Google Docs' version history, but for code.

Check:

```
git --version
```

✅ **Pass:** You see `git version 2.x.x` → skip to Check 4. ❌ **Fail:** A popup may appear asking you to install **Xcode Command Line Tools** — click **Install** and wait (this takes 5–10 minutes). If no popup appears, follow **Install B** below.

Install B — Git (manual)

1. Go to **https://git-scm.com/download/mac**
2. Download the installer for macOS

3. Run the `.pkg` file and follow the prompts
4. Re-run `git --version` to confirm

Check 4 — VS Code (Code Editor)

VS Code is your text editor for the project — like Microsoft Word but for code. You will use this to read, write, and edit files.

Check:

```
code --version
```

✅ **Pass:** You see a version number → skip to Part 2. ❌ **Fail:** Follow **Install C** below.

Install C — VS Code

1. Go to **https://code.visualstudio.com**
2. Click **Download for Mac**
3. Open the downloaded `.zip` file → drag **Visual Studio Code** into your **Applications** folder
4. Open VS Code from Applications
5. Inside VS Code, press `Command (⌘) + Shift + P` → type `shell command` → click **"Shell Command: Install 'code' command in PATH"**
6. Re-open Terminal and run `code --version` to confirm

PART 2 — GitHub Account Setup (Everyone)

GitHub is where the team's code lives. Think of it as a shared Google Drive, but specifically for code — with proper version tracking so nobody accidentally overwrites someone else's work.

Step 1 — Create a GitHub account

1. Go to **https://github.com**
2. Click **Sign up** and create a free account
3. Verify your email address
4. **Send your GitHub username to Deb** via your team chat

Step 2 — Configure Git with your name

In Terminal, run these two commands (replace the placeholder text with your actual name and the email you used for GitHub):

```
git config --global user.name "Your Full Name"
```

```
git config --global user.email "your@email.com"
```

No output = success. That's normal.

PART 3 — Getting the Project onto Your Mac

> **Wait for Deb to do this step first.** Deb will create the project repository on GitHub and send the team a link before anyone else runs these steps.

Once you have the link from Deb:

Step 1 — Clone the project

In Terminal, navigate to a folder where you want the project to live (your Desktop is fine):

```
cd ~/Desktop
```

Then clone (download) the project — replace `LINK-FROM-DEB` with the actual GitHub link she sends:

```
git clone LINK-FROM-DEB
```

This creates a folder called `mealmap` (or similar) on your Desktop.

Step 2 — Open the project in VS Code

```
cd mealmap
code .
```

VS Code will open with the full project visible in the left panel.

Step 3 — Install project dependencies

Still in Terminal (make sure you're inside the project folder from Step 2):

```
npm install
```

This downloads all the code libraries the project needs. You'll see a lot of text scroll by — this is normal. Wait for it to finish (usually 1–2 minutes).

PART 4 — API Key Setup

> **Deb coordinates this.** She will share the team's Anthropic API key securely (not via public chat or email). Do not post API keys anywhere.

Once you have the key from Deb:

Step 1 — Create your environment file

In VS Code, look at the left panel (the file explorer). Find the file called `.env.example`. Right-click it → **Copy**, then right-click in the same folder → **Paste**. Rename the copy to `.env` (just `.env` — no `.example`).

Step 2 — Add the API key

Open `.env` in VS Code. You'll see a line that looks like:

```
ANTHROPIC_API_KEY=
```

Paste the key Deb gave you after the `=` sign. Save the file (`Command + S`).

> ⚠️ The `.env` file will **not** be uploaded to GitHub — it's in the `.gitignore` list for exactly this reason. Your key stays local on your machine.

PART 5 — Running the App Locally

Start the app

In Terminal (inside the project folder):

```
npm run dev
```

Open it in your browser

Open any browser and go to:

```
http://localhost:3000
```

You should see the MealMap app.

To stop the app: click in Terminal and press `Control + C`.

PART 6 — Day-to-Day Workflow

Every day when you sit down to work:

Pull the latest changes first (before you start)

```
git pull
```

This fetches any changes your teammates made. Skipping this is like starting to edit a shared Google Doc from yesterday's version — you'll create conflicts.

Save your work at the end of the day

```
git add .
git commit -m "Brief description of what you did"
git push
```

For example:

```
git commit -m "Rashi: vision prompt v2 with confidence scores"
```

One rule: commit messages should say what changed, not just "update" or "fix." Future you will thank present you.

PART 7 — Role-Specific Notes

Rashi — Vision Module

Your prompt files live in `/prompts/vision/`. Never edit prompts directly in the JavaScript code — always save a new version in that folder and reference it. This makes it easy to roll back if a new prompt behaves worse.

Suba — Recipe Intelligence

Your prompt files live in `/prompts/recipe/`. The recipe prompt has a fixed JSON output

contract — if you change the shape of what Claude returns, tell Deb and Nikitha immediately, as their modules consume your output.

Nikitha — Personalisation & Safety

You own the `.env` UserProfile shape and the safety intercept function. The safety layer runs **before** any recipe card is rendered — if it breaks, nothing shows on screen. Test with a known allergen like "peanuts" after every change.

Deb — Integration & Deployment

You own the Vercel deployment. When it's time to deploy (end of build week), you'll need to add the `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` as an **Environment Variable** inside the Vercel dashboard — the `.env` file is only for local development and never goes to Vercel directly.

Quick Reference — Terminal Commands

What you want to do	Command
Open project folder	`cd ~/Desktop/mealmap`
Start the app	`npm run dev`
Stop the app	`Control + C`
Pull latest from team	`git pull`
See what you changed	`git status`
Save and push your work	`git add . && git commit -m "message" && git push`
Install new packages	`npm install`

Troubleshooting

"Port 3000 is already in use" Something is already running on that port. Run `npm run dev -- --port 3001` to use port 3001 instead, then go to `http://localhost:3001`.

"Cannot find module" error when starting the app You probably haven't installed dependencies. Run `npm install` first.

"Permission denied" when running git commands You may not have been added to the GitHub repository yet. Send your GitHub username to Deb.

VS Code doesn't show the project files Make sure you used `code .` (with the dot) from inside the project folder. The dot means "open the current folder."

The app loads but Claude API calls fail Check that your `.env` file exists, has no typos, and that the API key is correct. Restart the app after any `.env` changes (`Control + C`, then `npm run dev` again).